

Environment May Eclipse Vietnam as College Issue

By GLADWIN HILL Special to The New York Times

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LOS ANGELES, Nov. 29—
"We want to stop the war, end
pollution—and beat Stanford!"
yelled a Berkeley pep leader at
last weekend's big football
rally.

The mention of pollution
brought a roar of approval
from a University of California
crowd of 5,000 that almost
drowned out the reference to
the big game.

Rising concern about the "en-
vironmental crisis" is sweeping
the nation's campuses with an
intensity that may be on its
way to eclipsing student dis-
content over the war in Viet-
nam.

This is indicated by inter-
views with students and
faculty members from many
campuses and with leading
conservation authorities around
the country.

There is a strong feeling on
the campuses that the war will
be liquidated in due course.
Meanwhile, it is physically re-
mote. And, in the wake of the
big protest marches, many stu-
dents feel Vietnam offers only
limited scope for student ac-
tion.

But the deterioration of the
nation's "quality of life" is a
pervasive, here-and-now, long-
term problem that students of
all political shadings can sink
their teeth and energies into.
And they are doing it.

A national day of observance
of environmental problems,
analogous to the mass demons-

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Daniel Dmitruk for The New York Times
**University of Minnesota students conduct a mock funeral for the gasoline engine in
a protest against air pollution. Concern for "environmental crisis" is sweeping campuses.**

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trations on Vietnam, is being planned for next spring, with Congressional backing.

From Maine to Hawaii, students are seizing on the environmental ills from water pollution to the global population problem, campaigning against them, and pitching in to do something about them.

"A ground swell of concern is starting, on everything from population and food supply to the preservation of natural areas," commented Dr. Edward Clebsch, assistant professor of botany at the University of Tennessee.

"I've been floored by the intensity of their actions and feelings," said Dr. Vincent Arp, a Bureau of Standards physicist close to the University of Colorado at Boulder. "The student group is going like a bomb."

"They can see it, they can feel it, they can smell it. And they think they can change it," said William E. Felling, a program officer of the Ford Foundation, which contributes to many conservation activities.

In Los Angeles a fortnight ago, a student bloc stole the spotlight from 1,000 older participants in a gubernatorial environmental conference. Last week in San Francisco, at a meeting of the United States National Commission for UNESCO, something similar happened.

Words and Deeds

In Massachusetts last week, Boston University students put on a two-day campaign of public education in ecology. In Seattle, the University of Washington Committee on The Environmental Crisis was staging a similar "learn-in".

Words are only the surface of the iceberg. University of Minnesota students, fresh from a mock funeral demonstration against the fume-belching automobile engine, were planning to dump 26,000 cans on the lawn of a beverage manufacturer to protest use of such packaging. Northwestern University students were campaigning against a controversial regulatory proposal of the Chicago Sanitary District, and against the waste discharges of a big drug manufacturer.

At Stanford and the University of Texas, law students were researching new courtroom stratagems against despoilers of the environment. University of Arizona students in semisecrecy, were collecting data on the fume emissions of copper smelting operations.

Efforts Get Results

Already the student environmental front can point to many accomplishments. Student activists had significant roles in the campaigns to "save" San Francisco Bay and the northern California redwoods, and to block new dams on the Colorado River.

The University of Wisconsin's Ecology Student Association was active in the campaign against the recently truncated Project Sanguine, the Navy's high-power communications development; and provided important logistical support for the Environmental Defense Fund in the months-long Madison hearings on DDT.

At the University of Illinois at Champaign-Urbana, Students for Environmental Control sallied forth in freezing weather 10 days ago and extracted six tons of refuse from nearby Boneyard Creek. They persuaded city officials to follow up the effort, and are working on a beautification plan for the creek.

A University of Texas student is launching a state environmental newsletter. University of Washington students, on their own time, are preparing an 80-page report on ecological problems of Puget Sound. At the California Institute of Technology, students organized an intercollegiate summer research project in environmental problems that already has attracted nearly \$100,000 in foundation financing.

On some campuses—Vassar, the University of Oklahoma, and the University of Nebraska are examples—there are no evidences of organized environmental concern. But they are far outweighed by the ferment elsewhere.

On the University of Texas campus at Austin there are at least six environmental groups, with interests ranging from water pollution to conservation law. One group, in the College of Engineering, has filed 58 formal complaints against the University itself for pollution of a nearby creek. At the University of Hawaii, there are close to two dozen groups, each organized around a particular cause.

Action Is Keynote

Some groups, like Boston University's Ecology Coalition, have as few as a dozen members. Others have hundreds. But with causes on every hand, mass membership and parliamentary formalities mean less than action, which can be initiated by a handful of people. Then the causes gather their own following.

A few groups cherish the designation of "radical" and are indirect offshoots of the leftist movements like the Students for a Democratic Society and California's Peace and Freedom Party.

"Capitalism is predicated on money and growth, and when you're only interested to maximize profits, you maximize pollution. We need a system that takes maximum care of the earth," said Cliff Humphrey,

the 32-year-old leader of Ecology Action, one of several groups at Berkeley.

But generally the aura of the environmental "new wave" is conservative, with coats and ties as conspicuous as beards and blue jeans. "There's a role for everybody in ecology," said Keith Lampe, a cofounder of the Yippie movement, who puts out an environment-oriented newsletter from Berkeley. "People with widely different styles and politics can talk to each other with no more tension than a Presbyterian talks with a Methodist."

Few 'Anarchists'

"I doubt if you'll find many anarchist ecologists," commented Steve Berwick, a 28-year-old Yale environmentalist. "Ecology is a system, and anarchy goes against that."

A typical group is Boston University's Ecology Action, whose 75 members are led by Bruce Tisney, a 20-year-old junior geology major. Edward, a hippie rather than a hippie in appearance, he has a trimmed red beard, wide-rimmed spectacles, and affects such sartorial accoutrements as a blue plaid vest and a matching bow-tie, white shirt, and gold watch and chain.

Ecology Action's two-day educational program last week, included "friendly" picketing of the state capitol, a pollution film festival, pamphleteering and lectures, and a mock award of a pollution prize to a local power company. The group has been conferring with state water pollution officials about doing spare time "watchdog" work, and is planning to set up dust-catching devices to monitor air pollution.

There have, across the country, been incidents, but mostly minor—such as the arrest last month of 26 University of Texas students who tried to block the felling of some trees for a campus building extension.

Local Orientation

Some of the campus groups are branches of national organizations such as the Sierra Club (which has just installed a campus coordinator at its San Francisco headquarters), the Wildlife Federation, and the newly established Friends of the Earth. But most of them are spontaneous local movements. Many tend to shun the established national organizations as being dedicated to old-line "conservation" rather than the environmental crisis. They also feel the older groups are wary of "direct action" for fear of losing their financial base. Ad hoc student groups don't have this problem.

"We don't want to be labeled as 'conservationists' or 'antipollution'," said Wes Fisher, a 26-year-old ecology student at the University of Minnesota. "Pollution and overpopulation are like a web, and pollution is just the symptom."

The students are employing the gamut of communications and political-pressure techniques—meetings, lectures, rallies, picketing, research, pamphleteering, letter-writing, petitions, legislative testimony, collaboration with public agencies and contacts with politicians.

Last month, Illinois' representative William Springer, Republican, felt student heat when conservationists from the University of Illinois picketed a testimonial dinner for him because he backed a controversial dam project.

Impetus Is Recent

The environmental "new wave" gathered in California as far back as 1965, when Berkeley students staged a sitdown protest against a freeway and Stanford students became involved in campaigns for San Francisco Bay, the redwoods, and Point Reyes National Seashore.

But most of the organizing is recent, and is proceeding unabated. A Boston University group was sparked by a recent Ramparts magazine article by Stanford's Dr. Paul Ehrlich, the "population bomb" crusader. San Francisco State College students were galvanized by a speaker from the Planned Parenthood organization. Bob Hertz, an organizer of the University of Minnesota's Students for Environmental Defense, said his inspiration came from Zen Buddhism and its emphasis on the interrelationship of man and nature. A student group gathering strength at Ohio State was motivated by concern over the Army Engineers' Clear Creek Dam project in southern Ohio, which threatened to flood a pristine natural area used by science students.

In more instances than not, students are welcoming faculty collaboration and counsel. In some places, faculty members have taken the lead. At the University of Arizona in Tucson, a philosophy professor, David Yetman, and a recent law graduate, William Risner, organized "GASP" (Group Against Smelter Pollution) to do battle with the copper companies. The group now includes students and townspeople.

Academic Growth

A University of Illinois engineering instructor, Bruce Hannon, has been a leader of the Committee on Allerton Park, opposing a \$70-million Army Engineers dam project near Decatur. Students joined in a campaign that led to the University's commissioning of an engineering firm to produce an alternative plan.

The environmental ferment caused Ohio State to establish a School of Natural Resources last year. Its original involve-

ment of 180 has grown quickly to 300. An introductory conservation course that had 147 students last fall had 210 this fall. The college's perennial Biologists Forum, which used to draw 20 persons to its meetings, has been attracting hundreds. The University of Tennessee reports an enthusiastic reception for a new course in "Biology and Human Affairs."

Colby College in Waterville, Me., has organized two special seminars in January and February on pollution problems and conservation law.

Students are taking the initiative in some environmental teaching. At Stanford, Jeff Bauman, a 22-year-old senior majoring in biology, this fall has been attracting 20 to 40 students to an informal after-dinner dormitory seminar.

Overshadowing Vietnam

There are differing indications on the campuses about how soon environment may overshadow Vietnam in student interest, but the trend is evident.

"A lot of people are becoming disenchanted with the antiwar movement," said Boston University's Bruce Tiffney. "People who are frustrated and disillusioned are starting to turn to ecology."

"I think environment is a bigger issue than the war, and

I think people are beginning to sense its urgency," said Robert Benner, a 22-year-old geology student in the University of Colorado conservation movement.

"The country is tired of S.D.S. and ready to see someone like us come to the forefront," remarked Alan Tucker, a member of Ecology Activists at San Francisco State.

"Environmental problems will obviously replace other major issues of today," said Terry Cornelius, president of the University of Washington's committee on the environmental crises. "This is not just a social movement for Biafra or Vietnam, but for everybody and our closed system, Earth."

"Environment will replace Vietnam as a major issue with the students as the Vietnam phase-out proceeds," commented A. Bruce Etherington, chairman of the University of Hawaii's architecture department. "And it will not be just a political lever to be used by radicals."

Many of the "over-30" environmentalists see the student movement as the catalyst, if not the main driving force, that will get environmental improvement rolling and overcome the older generation's tacit resignation to the status quo.

"These kids are really re-

markable in their understanding and maturity," said 52-year-old Dr. Barry Commoner, the prominent Washington University ecologist who has been addressing many student groups.

Campuses are seen as representing a greatly broadened base for the "conservation constituency" needed to jog bureaucrats and support the politicians through whom environmental reforms generally must clear.

Conservation lawyers look to campuses for the scientific expertise vital in pressing environmental battles in the courts, and for the energy necessary to raise funds for the usually expensive legal proceedings.

Indications are that coming months will see the student conservation tide swelling and manifesting itself in an arresting variety of ways.

Already students are looking forward to the first "D-Day" of the movement, next April 22—when a nationwide environmental "teach-in", being coordinated from the office of Senator Gaylord Nelson, Wisconsin Democrat, is planned, to involve both college campuses and communities.

Given the present rising pitch of interest, some supporters think, it could be a bigger and more meaningful event than the antiwar demonstrations.



PROTEST: A group of girls demonstrate against the smog in Los Angeles. Conservation groups are erupting at colleges all over country and may eclipse discontent over the war.